

Chapter 1: The Board and Pieces (ELO 0 -> 200)

“You cannot play a symphony before you’ve tuned your instrument.”

1.1 The Chessboard

Before touching a single piece, you must know the battlefield.

The 64 Squares

A chessboard has **64 squares** arranged in an 8x8 grid. The squares alternate between **light** and **dark**.

	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h	
8									8
7									7
6									6
5									5
4									4
3									3
2									2
1									1
	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h	

Files and Ranks

- **Files** are vertical columns (a-h). File a is on White’s left.
- **Ranks** are horizontal rows (1-8). Rank 1 is White’s home row.
- Every square has a unique name: **file + rank** (e.g., e4, h1, a8).

The Golden Rule of Setup

“Light square on the right.”

When sitting at the board, the bottom-right corner square (h1 for White, a8 for Black) must be a light square. If it’s dark, you’ve set the board wrong.

Center vs. Edge

The four center squares – **d4, d5, e4, e5** – are the most important real estate on the board. A piece in the center controls more squares than a piece on the edge.

- A knight on e4 attacks 8 squares
- A knight on a1 attacks only 2 squares

Key Insight: You want your pieces in or near the center. Always.

1.2 The Pieces

There are **6 types of pieces**, each with unique movement patterns.

The King (K)

Value: The game itself. Lose the king, lose the game.

Movement: One square in any direction – horizontal, vertical, or diagonal.

```
. . . . . . . .
. . . . . . . .
. . . . . . . .
. . x x x . . .
. . x K x . . .  <- King on e4, can move to any 'x'
. . x x x . . .
. . . . . . . .
. . . . . . . .
```

Special rules: - Cannot move into check (onto a square attacked by an enemy piece) - Cannot move next to the enemy king (kings must stay one square apart)
- **Castling** (see Section 1.5): A special move with the rook

The Queen (Q)

Value: 9 points. Your most powerful piece.

Movement: Any number of squares in any direction – horizontally, vertically, or diagonally. Think: rook + bishop combined.

```
. . . x . . . .
x . . x . . . x
. x . x . x . .
. . x x x . . .
x x x Q x x x x  <- Queen on d4
. . x x x . . .
. x . x . x . .
x . . x . . . x
```

The Rook (R)

Value: 5 points.

Movement: Any number of squares horizontally or vertically.

```
. . . x . . . .
. . . x . . . .
. . . x . . . .
```

```

. . . x . . .
x x x R x x x x  <- Rook on e4
. . . x . . .
. . . x . . .
. . . x . . .

```

The Bishop (B)

Value: 3 points.

Movement: Any number of squares diagonally. Each bishop stays on squares of one color for its entire life – a “light-squared bishop” or “dark-squared bishop.”

```

x . . . . . x
. x . . . . x .
. . x . . x . .
. . . x x . . .
. . . B x . . .  <- Bishop on d4
. . . x x . . .
. . x . . x . .
x . . . . . x

```

The Knight (N)

Value: 3 points.

Movement: In an “L” shape – two squares in one direction, then one square perpendicular. The knight is the only piece that can **jump over other pieces**.

```

. . . . . . .
. . x . x . . .
. x . . . x . .
. . . N . . . .  <- Knight on d4
. x . . . x . .
. . x . x . . .
. . . . . . .
. . . . . . .

```

Memory trick: Think of a knight move as “one-two-and-turn” – one square straight, two squares straight, then turn to the side for one.

The Pawn (P)

Value: 1 point. But don’t underestimate them – pawns are the soul of chess.

Movement: - **Forward only**, one square at a time - On its **first move only**, a pawn may advance **two squares** - Pawns **capture diagonally** (one square forward-left or forward-right)

```

. . . . . . .

```

```

. . . . .
. . . . .
. . . . .
. . x x . . .
. . . P . . . <- White pawn on e4
. . . . .
. . . . .

```

The pawn on e4 can: - Move to e5 (one square forward) - Capture on d5 (diagonal left) - Capture on f5 (diagonal right)

Critical rule: Pawns capture differently than they move. This is the #1 mistake beginners make.

1.3 Piece Values (The Point System)

Understanding piece values helps you make good trades:

Piece	Points	Nickname
Queen	9	The Powerhouse
Rook	5	The Tower
Bishop	3	The Sniper
Knight	3	The Trickster
Pawn	1	The Soldier

The king has no point value – it's priceless. You can never trade your king.

Good Trades, Bad Trades

- **Winning a trade:** Trading a knight (3) for a rook (5) = +2 advantage
- **Losing a trade:** Trading a rook (5) for a bishop (3) = -2 disadvantage
- **Equal trade:** Bishop (3) for knight (3) = even

The Rule of Thumb: Don't trade a stronger piece for a weaker one unless you get something concrete in return (checkmate, a winning attack, or a soon-to-be-promoted pawn).

1.4 The Starting Position

```

      a  b  c  d  e  f  g  h
8 | r  n  b  q  k  b  n  r | 8 Black
7 | p  p  p  p  p  p  p  p | 7
6 | .  .  .  .  .  .  .  . | 6

```

5		.	.	.	.	.	.	.	.		5
4		.	.	.	.	.	.	.	.		4
3		.	.	.	.	.	.	.	.		3
2		P	P	P	P	P	P	P	P		2
1		R	N	B	Q	K	B	N	R		1 White
		a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h		

Setup checklist: 1. Rooks in the corners (a1, h1, a8, h8) 2. Knights next to rooks (b1, g1, b8, g8) 3. Bishops next to knights (c1, f1, c8, f8) 4. Queen on her own color: White queen on d1 (light), Black queen on d8 (dark) 5. King on the remaining center square 6. Pawns fill the second rank for each side

Memory trick: “Queen on her own color.” If White’s queen is on a dark square, something is wrong.

1.5 Special Moves

Castling

The only move where you move two pieces at once – the king moves two squares toward a rook, and the rook jumps over the king.

Requirements (all must be true): 1. Neither the king nor the castling rook has moved yet 2. No pieces between the king and the rook 3. The king is not in check 4. The king does not move through or into check

Kingside castling (O-O): King moves to g1/g8, rook to f1/f8

Queenside castling (O-O-O): King moves to c1/c8, rook to d1/d8

En Passant

French for “in passing.” If a pawn moves two squares forward (using its first-move privilege) and lands beside an enemy pawn, the enemy pawn can capture it *as if it had only moved one square*.

This capture must be made **immediately** on the very next move – or the opportunity is lost forever.

Pawn Promotion

When a pawn reaches the opposite end of the board (rank 8 for White, rank 1 for Black), it must promote to a queen, rook, bishop, or knight of the same color. Nearly always, you promote to a **queen**.

1.6 Check, Checkmate, and Stalemate

Check

The king is under attack. The player in check **must** get out of check on their next move. There are three ways:

1. **Move** the king to a safe square
2. **Block** the check by putting a piece between the king and attacker (doesn't work against knights)
3. **Capture** the checking piece

Checkmate

The king is in check and **none of the three escape methods work**. The game ends immediately – the player who delivered checkmate wins.

The fastest possible checkmate is **Fool's Mate** (two moves):

1. f3? e5
2. g4?? Qh4#

Stalemate

The king is **not** in check, but the player has **no legal moves**. The game ends in a draw (tie). Stalemate is a common pitfall for beginners – you must always give the opponent's king a legal square when you're winning!

1.7 Your First Goal: The Ladder Mate

Before you learn anything else, learn to checkmate with **king + queen vs. king** (or king + rook). This is called the “ladder mate” because you push the enemy king to the edge like climbing rungs of a ladder.

The Method (with Queen): 1. Use your queen to cut off the enemy king – place it a “knight's move away” 2. When the enemy king is on the edge, bring your own king close 3. Deliver checkmate with the queen protected by your king

Practice this 20 times. If you can't do this in your sleep, you're not ready for ELO 200.

Chapter 1 Summary

Concept	What You Must Know
Board layout	Files a-h, ranks 1-8, light square on right
Piece movement	All 6 pieces, how they move and capture

Concept	What You Must Know
Piece values	Q=9, R=5, B=3, N=3, P=1
Special moves	Castling, en passant, promotion
Check vs. Checkmate vs. Stalemate	Know the difference cold
Ladder mate	K+Q vs K checkmate pattern

Checkpoint: Can you set up the board from memory? Do you know how every piece moves without hesitation? Can you checkmate a lone king with king + queen? If yes, proceed to Chapter 2. # Chapter 2: Basic Principles (ELO 200 -> 400)

“Chess is 99% tactics.” – Richard Teichmann

2.1 The Three Golden Rules of the Opening

For the first 10-15 moves of every game, you have three jobs. Memorize them:

Rule 1: Control the Center

The center squares (e4, d4, e5, d5) are the high ground. Pieces in the center attack more squares and reach both sides of the board faster.

Good first moves: 1. e4, 1. d4, 1. Nf3, 1. c4 **Bad first moves:** 1. a4, 1. h4, 1. Na3 (these ignore the center)

The test: After every move, ask yourself – “Did this move increase my control over the center?”

Rule 2: Develop Your Pieces (Quickly!)

“Development” means bringing your pieces off the back rank and into the game. An undeveloped piece is a soldier asleep in the barracks.

The ideal first 10 moves: - Move both center pawns (e4/d4 for White, e5/d5 for Black) - Bring out both knights (usually to c3/f3 or c6/f6) - Bring out both bishops (to active diagonals) - Castle to safety

The rule of thumb: Don’t move the same piece twice in the opening unless forced. Every time you move a piece that’s already developed, you waste time another piece could have used.

Rule 3: King Safety (Castle Early!)

An uncastled king is a vulnerable king. Castle within the first 5-10 moves.

Which side? - **Kingside** (O-O): Faster (only 2 pieces to move first), safer in most positions - **Queenside** (O-O-O): Useful when you want to attack on the kingside

When in doubt, castle kingside. Until ELO 1000, castling queenside is usually overthinking it.

What NOT to Do in the Opening

Mistake	Why It's Bad
Bringing the queen out early	She becomes a target, and you waste moves retreating
Moving pawns on the edge (a4, h4)	Doesn't help development or center control
Making too many pawn moves	Pawns don't "develop" – pieces do
Not castling	Your king sits in the center, an open target
Opening with the rook's pawn	Literally the worst first move. Don't.

2.2 Developing a “Board Sense”

Between ELO 200-400, most games are lost because one player simply doesn't see that their piece is being attacked.

The Pre-Move Checklist

Before you touch a piece, ask three questions:

1. **Checks:** Can I check my opponent? Can my opponent check me?
2. **Captures:** What can I capture? What can my opponent capture (especially my undefended pieces)?
3. **Threats:** What am I threatening? What is my opponent threatening?

This is the **CCT Framework** (Checks, Captures, Threats) – which we will dive deep into in Chapter 3. For now, get in the habit of scanning for CCT on every move.

Hanging Pieces

A “hanging” piece is one that is undefended and can be captured for free. At the 200-400 level, most decisive advantages come from simply not hanging your pieces and capturing your opponent's hanging pieces.

Exercise: Before every move, scan the entire board and ask: “Does my opponent have any pieces that aren't protected? Do I have any undefended pieces they could take?”

2.3 Counting Attackers and Defenders

When pieces clash, you need to know who comes out ahead.

The Counting Rule

Before capturing, count: 1. How many of your pieces attack the target square
2. How many of your opponent's pieces defend it 3. The value of the pieces involved

If attackers > defenders: You can safely capture – your opponent will run out of pieces first.

If attackers = defenders: The exchange may be equal, but if you're capturing with a lesser piece first, you might win material.

Example: Attacking a Defended Pawn

White wants to capture the pawn on d5.

d5 is defended by Black's knight on f6 and queen on d8.

White attacks d5 with: knight on c3, bishop on g2, pawn on e4.

Attackers (Nc3, Bg2, e-pawn) = 3

Defenders (Nf6, Qd8) = 2

3 > 2 -> White can win the pawn!

But be careful: the **order of captures matters**. Capture with the least valuable piece first.

In this case: pawn takes (1), then knight/queen trade (if they recapture), then bishop takes – White ends up winning a pawn.

2.4 Introduction to Tactics

Tactics are short, forcing sequences that win material or deliver checkmate. At the 200-400 level, you need to master three basic patterns.

The Fork

A single piece attacks two (or more) enemy pieces simultaneously. The opponent can only save one.

The Knight Fork is the most common and dangerous fork because knights jump in unexpected ways.

White knight on e5:

- Checks Black king on g8
- Attacks Black queen on d7

Black must move the king, losing the queen.

Position to remember: A knight on e5 (or e4 for Black) forking king + rook is one of the most common tactical wins at beginner level.

The Pin

A piece is “pinned” when moving it would expose a more valuable piece behind it to attack.

Absolute pin: The pinned piece **cannot** legally move (because it would expose the king to check).

Relative pin: The piece *can* move, but doing so loses material.

Black bishop on b4 pins White knight on c3 to the king on e1.

The knight cannot move -- it's absolutely pinned.

Exploiting a pin: Attack the pinned piece with a pawn or lesser piece. It can't run away!

The Skewer

Like a pin, but the more valuable piece is in front. The front piece must move, exposing the piece behind to capture.

White rook on e1, Black king on e8, Black queen on a8 (same rank).

The rook checks the king -- the king must move, and then rook captures queen.

This is an "X-ray" attack through the king to the queen.

The Discovered Attack

When you move a piece and uncover an attack from another piece behind it. Devastating when combined with check.

White bishop on c4, White knight on d5, Black queen on a5, Black king on g8.

Knight moves from d5 to f6 -- DISCOVERED CHECK from the bishop!

After king moves, knight captures the queen on a5 (if she moved to h5, say).

2.5 Basic Checkmate Patterns

At ELO 200-400, you must be able to recognize and execute these checkmates without thinking.

Back Rank Mate

The enemy king is trapped on the back rank by its own pawns. A rook or queen delivers checkmate along that rank.

	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h			
8		.	.	.	.	.	R	.	k		8
7		.	.	.	.	.	.	.	p		7
6		.	.	.	.	.	.	p	.		6

(White rook to e8 is checkmate)

Prevention: Give your king “luft” (air) by moving a pawn in front of the castled king (h3/h6 or g3/g6).

Smothered Mate

A knight delivers checkmate to a king completely surrounded by its own pieces.

Black king on g8, surrounded by rook on f8 and pawns on g7, h7.
White knight on h6 checks. The king can't move -- smothered mate!

Queen + Knight/Bishop Mate

Queen protected by a knight or bishop, delivering checkmate to a king on the edge:

White king on g6, White queen on h7, Black king on h8.
The queen delivers checkmate defended by the king -- king can't capture.

2.6 Common Beginner Mistakes (And How to Fix Them)

Mistake 1: Copycat Chess

Just mirroring the opponent's moves. This is dangerous because the player who copies moves *second* is always one move behind when the original player breaks the pattern with a capture or check.

Fix: Play your own plan. Don't just mirror.

Mistake 2: Premature Attacks

Attacking before you've finished development. You bring 2-3 pieces while the opponent has all pieces developed – your attack fizzles, and they counter-attack.

Fix: Complete development first. Castle. Then attack.

Mistake 3: Trading for No Reason

Capturing pieces just because you can, without asking if the trade benefits you.

Fix: Before every capture, ask: “Does this trade improve my position?” If you’re not sure, don’t capture.

Mistake 4: Neglecting King Safety

Leaving the king in the center past move 10, or pushing pawns in front of a castled king without purpose.

Fix: Castle early. Think twice before moving pawns in front of your king.

Mistake 5: Resigning Too Early

At the 200-400 level, comebacks happen constantly. Opponents blunder, stale-mate you, or flag in time trouble.

Fix: Never resign. Make your opponent prove they can win.

Chapter 2 Summary

Principle	Key Takeaway
Three opening rules	Center, develop, castle
Pre-move checklist	Checks -> Captures -> Threats
Counting	Attackers vs. Defenders
Basic tactics	Fork, pin, skewer, discovered attack
Checkmate patterns	Back rank, smothered, queen support
Common mistakes	Don’t mirror, don’t attack undeveloped, castle early

Checkpoint: Can you name the three opening rules? Can you spot a fork, pin, or skewer when it’s on the board? Do you count attackers and defenders before capturing? If yes, proceed to Chapter 3. # Chapter 3: Tactical Foundations – The CCT System (ELO 400 -> 600)

“The winner of the game is the player who makes the next-to-last mistake.” – Savielly Tartakower

This is the most important chapter in the book. The CCT system is the same framework used by the Chess99 Tactical Progression Trainer. Master this, and you will never look at a chess position the same way again.

3.1 Why Tactics Win Games at This Level

Between ELO 400-600, games are decided by tactics – not strategy, not positional understanding, not opening theory. The player who spots one more tactic than their opponent wins.

The hard truth: At this level, 80% of games are decided by: 1. One player hangs a piece 2. One player misses a simple tactic 3. One player doesn't see a checkmate in 1-2 moves

Your job is to stop being the player who misses these.

3.2 The CCT Framework

CCT stands for Checks, Captures, Threats. It's a systematic way to analyze any position. Think of it as a pre-move checklist that you run on every single turn.

The CCT Scan (For YOUR Move)

Before you make a move, scan in this exact order:

1. CHECKS: "Can I check my opponent's king?"
2. CAPTURES: "What can I capture? In what order?"
3. THREATS: "What threats can I create that my opponent must respond to?"

Why this order? Checks are the most forcing – your opponent *must* respond to a check. Captures are next – if the piece is valuable enough, they must recapture. Threats are third – they give your opponent choices, but good threats still force a response.

The CCT Scan (For THEIR Move)

After your opponent moves, run the scan from their perspective:

1. "What check did they just threaten?"
2. "What can they capture (especially my hanging pieces)?"
3. "What threat did they create (fork, pin, discovery)?"

The golden rule: If the opponent's move looks strange or suspicious, there's probably a tactic. Ask: "What does that move threaten that wasn't threatened before?"

3.3 Checks – The Most Forcing Move

A check must be answered. When you give check, the opponent has only three options: 1. Move the king 2. Block the check 3. Capture the checking piece

This makes checks the ultimate “forcing move” – you control what happens next.

Check With a Purpose

Don’t check just because you can. Every check should have a goal:

Type of Check	Purpose
Driving check	Force the king to a worse square
Discovery check	Uncover an attack from another piece while checking
Double check	Check from two pieces simultaneously (king must move!)
Checkmate	End the game

The Power of Double Check

A double check is the most powerful move in chess. The king **must move** – you cannot block or capture two checking pieces at once.

White king on e1, Black rook on e8, Black bishop on a5.
White knight on d4 moves to c6 -- DOUBLE CHECK!

The king must move (to d1, d2, f1, or f2).
After the king moves... the knight captures the queen on d8.

3.4 Captures – The Most Common Tactic

Captures are where most material is won or lost. The key is finding the right capture order.

The Capture Hierarchy

When multiple captures are possible on the same square:

1. **Pawns capture first** (cheapest)
2. **Minor pieces next** (knights, bishops = 3 points)
3. **Rooks next** (5 points)
4. **Queen last** (9 points)

Always capture with the least valuable piece first. If you lead with the queen, you might lose her.

The Removal of the Defender

Sometimes you can't capture the piece you want because it's defended. The solution: **capture the defender first**.

Black knight on f6 defends the pawn on d5. White wants the d5 pawn. White bishop captures Black knight on f6. Black recaptures. NOW the d5 pawn is undefended -- White captures it.

This is called "removing the defender" or "undermining." It's one of the most common tactical ideas at the intermediate level.

Desperado

When one of your pieces is going to be captured, make sure it takes something with it.

White knight on e5 is attacked by Black's pawn on d6. White can capture the Black queen on f7 with the knight first -- even though the knight will be captured next move, it dies a hero.

A desperado piece "sells its life dearly" by taking the most valuable enemy piece it can before being captured.

3.5 Threats – Creating Problems for Your Opponent

A threat is a move that creates a problem your opponent must solve. The best threats are those that create multiple problems at once.

Types of Threats

Threat	Description	Difficulty to Spot
Fork	One piece attacks two	Easy
Pin	Immobilize a defender	Medium
Skewer	Force valuable piece to move	Medium
Discovered attack	Uncover attack by moving a piece	Hard
Zwischenzug	"In-between move" before expected recapture	Hard

Zwischenzug (The In-Between Move)

Your opponent expects you to recapture immediately. Instead, you throw in a check or threat first, then recapture.

Sequence: White captures Black knight on c6. Black's natural reply is to recapture. But before recapturing... Black checks White's king with Qa5+! After White blocks or moves... NOW Black recaptures on c6.

This in-between check won the tempo and possibly material.

Creating a Fork

The most common way to create a fork: put a piece on a square where it attacks two valuable enemy pieces.

The Knight Fork Checklist: 1. Scan for squares where a knight could attack two valuable pieces 2. Especially squares that fork the king and queen, or queen and rook 3. Knights on e5/e4 (for White) and e4/e5 (for Black) are common fork squares

3.6 The Blunder Check – The Most Important Habit

Every time you're about to make a move, do a **blunder check**:

1. **What will my opponent's best reply be?**
2. **Am I moving a piece to an attacked square?**
3. **Am I leaving something undefended?**

This takes 2-3 seconds and will save you more pieces than any other single habit.

Sitting on Your Hands

A practical tip: when you've decided on a move, sit on your hands for 5 seconds. Look at the board one more time. Ask: "Is there a check? A capture? A threat I've missed?"

Many blunders happen because players move instantly after deciding – without doing a final blunder check.

3.7 Common Tactical Themes at the 400-600 Level

Theme 1: The f7/f2 Square

The f7 square (for Black) and f2 square (for White) are the weakest squares on the board at the start of the game. They're only defended by the king!

Scholar's Mate: The classic 4-move checkmate targeting f7:

1. e4 e5
2. Bc4 Nc6
3. Qh5 Nf6??
4. Qxf7#

At ELO 400-600, opponents still fall for this. But more importantly, the **threat** of Scholar's Mate often forces weakening moves.

Theme 2: The Knight on the Rim

“Knight on the rim is dim.” A knight on the edge of the board controls half as many squares. Look for opportunities to trap a knight on the edge (a-file or h-file).

Theme 3: Overloaded Defender

A piece that’s defending two things simultaneously is “overloaded.” Attack one of the things it’s defending, and the defender can’t protect both.

Black queen on d8 defends both the rook on a8 and the knight on f6. White plays Bxf6 -- Black wants to recapture with the queen, but if she moves, White plays Rxa8 winning the rook. The queen is overloaded!

Theme 4: Discovered Attack With Tempo

Moving a piece to reveal an attack, while the moving piece also creates a threat:

White bishop on c4, White knight on d4, Black queen on a5, Black rook on h8. Nf5! (threatening Nxg7+, forking king and rook)
Black must deal with the knight's threat, but meanwhile...
The bishop on c4 now attacks f7! Two threats at once.

3.8 Building the CCT Habit

This chapter is useless if you don’t build the CCT scan into your thinking process. Here’s how to practice:

Training Method: The 30-Second CCT Scan

1. Go to any chess puzzle position
2. Set a timer for 30 seconds
3. Count: “Checks: ____ possible from me. Captures: ____ possible from me. Threats: ____ possible from me.”
4. Now do the same for your opponent
5. Only AFTER the full scan, start calculating

Do this 50 times. By puzzle 50, you’ll do the CCT scan in 10 seconds automatically.

Training Method: Blind CCT

Take a chess position, study it for 30 seconds, then look away. From memory: -
Name every check you have - Name every capture you have
- Name every undefended enemy piece

This builds visualization – the ability to “see” the board in your mind.

3.9 Connecting to the Chess99 Tactical Trainer

The Chess99 Tactical Progression Trainer uses exactly this CCT framework. When solving puzzles:

1. **CCT Phase 1 (Your Turn):** Click your pieces to identify your checks, captures, and threats
2. **CCT Phase 2 (Opponent's Turn):** Click enemy pieces to identify their checks, captures, and threats
3. **Solving Phase:** Only after completing both CCT phases, solve the puzzle

This mirrors exactly how you should think in a real game. Practice this in the trainer, and it becomes automatic over the board.

Pro tip: In the trainer, you must identify at least 50% of CCTs to proceed. This teaches you to be thorough – don't stop after finding just one thing!

Chapter 3 Summary

Skill	What You Must Master
CCT Scan	Checks -> Captures -> Threats (every move, both sides)
Blunder Check	5-second final scan before moving
Capture Order	Least valuable piece first
Removal of Defender	Capture the defender, then the target
Tactical Themes	f7/f2 weakness, overloaded defender, knight on rim, discovered attacks
CCT Practice	50 puzzles minimum, 30-second scan each

Checkpoint: Do you automatically scan for checks, captures, and threats on every move? Can you spot a fork, pin, skewer, and discovered attack? Do you do a blunder check before every move? If yes, proceed to Chapter 4. # Chapter 4: Opening Basics (ELO 600 -> 800)

“The opening is the phase where you bring your pieces out, not where you try to win the game.”

At the 600-800 level, players start knowing some opening moves but don't understand *why* they're playing them. This chapter teaches you the principles behind the moves, not just the moves themselves.

4.1 Opening Principles (Revisited and Deepened)

You learned the basics in Chapter 2. Now let's understand *why* they work.

The Four Opening Goals (In Priority Order)

Goal	Why	How to Check
1. Control the center	Center pieces attack more squares	Am I occupying or threatening e4/d4 (White) or e5/d5 (Black)?
2. Develop pieces	Active pieces win games	How many pieces are still on the back rank?
3. Castle to safety	Central king = target	Is my king castled by move 10?
4. Connect rooks	Rooks work best together	After castling + queen moves, are my rooks connected?

The Development Race

Think of the opening as a race: both players try to get their pieces out first. The player who “wins the race” – develops faster – can attack first.

How to measure development: - Count developed pieces (knights and bishops off the back rank, king castled) - After move 8: you should have 4+ pieces developed - After move 12: all minor pieces developed + king castled

4.2 A Simple White Opening: The Italian Game

For White, you need ONE opening. The **Italian Game** is ideal for beginners – it follows all principles, develops naturally, and teaches sound chess.

- | | | |
|---------|------|---|
| 1. e4 | e5 | (Both claim the center) |
| 2. Nf3 | Nc6 | (Develop knights, attack/defend e5-e4) |
| 3. Bc4 | Bc5 | (Develop bishops to active diagonals, target f7/f2) |
| 4. c3 | | (Prepare d4, reinforce the center) |
| 4. ... | Nf6 | (Black develops, attacks e4) |
| 5. d4 | | (Strike in the center!) |
| 5. ... | exd4 | (Black captures) |
| 6. cxd4 | | (Recapture, maintaining center presence) |
| 6. ... | Bb4+ | (Black checks -- a common try for counterplay) |
| 7. Nc3 | | (Block the check while developing) |

After this sequence: - White has knights on c3 and f3, bishop on c4, pawns controlling the center - White is ready to castle kingside - White has a slight space advantage

The Key Ideas Behind the Italian

1. **Bc4 targets f7** – the weakest square in Black’s camp
2. **c3 followed by d4** – the “classical center” formation. Pawns on e4 and d4 give White a space advantage
3. **Nf3 before Nc3** – the knight on f3 defends e4 and eyes the center

When Black Plays Differently

If 3... Nf6 (Two Knights Defense) instead of 3... Bc5:

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Nf6 4. Ng5! d5 5. exd5 Nxd5? 6. Nxf7!

White sacrifices a knight to expose Black’s king. This is the “Fried Liver Attack” – sound and deadly at this level.

If Black plays the French (1. e4 e6): Your Italian setup doesn’t work directly. Instead:

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 (defend e4) or 3. Nd2 (Tarrasch, avoid pin)

Don’t panic if Black doesn’t play e5 – adapt but keep the principles.

4.3 A Simple Black Opening: Responding to 1. e4

As Black, you need a solid response to White’s most common first move.

Option A: Play 1... e5 (Symmetrical, Classical)

The simplest approach – mirror White’s good moves:

1. e4 e5
2. Nf3 Nc6 (Defend the e5 pawn)
3. Bc4 Bc5 (Symmetrical Italian -- "Giuoco Piano")

After this, develop kingside knight (Nf6), castle, develop queenside. Sound and solid.

Option B: The Scandinavian Defense (Easy to Learn)

1. e4 d5 (Immediately challenge the center!)
2. exd5 Qxd5 (White captures, Black recaptures with queen)
3. Nc3 Qa5 (Attack the queen with tempo, queen retreats to safety)

Then Black plays Nf6, Bg4/Bf5, e6, c6, Nbd7... simple development. The queen retreats early but has a safe home on a5 or d8.

Pros: Highly forcing, White’s options are limited, the positions are easy to understand **Cons:** Queen moves early (violates a principle), but it’s safe here because White can’t attack it effectively

4.4 Understanding Tempo

Tempo (plural: tempi) = a unit of time in chess. One move = one tempo. The player who wastes fewer tempi develops faster.

Gaining a Tempo

You “gain a tempo” when you develop a piece while simultaneously making a threat that forces the opponent to waste a move responding.

```
1. e4 d5
2. exd5 Qxd5
3. Nc3      <- White develops the knight AND attacks the queen.
              Black must move the queen -- White gained a tempo!
```

Losing a Tempo

Moving the same piece twice in the opening (without a good reason) loses a tempo.

```
1. e4 e5
2. Nf3 Nc6
3. Bc4 Nf6
4. Ng5 d5
5. exd5 Nxd5??
6. Nxf7! Kxf7
7. Qf3+ Ke8    <- Black's king has moved multiple times, White is attacking
```

The Principle: Develop With Threat

The ideal opening move **develops a piece AND creates a threat**. This is the most efficient use of a tempo.

4.5 Opening Traps to Avoid (and Occasionally Use)

Traps You’ll Face as White

The Damiano Defense Trap:

```
1. e4 e5  2. Nf3 f6?? <- Damiano Defense. The worst defense of e5!
3. Nxe5! fxe5        <- If they capture...
4. Qh5+!             <- Double attack: king + e5 pawn
```

If 4... g6 then 5. Qxe5+ forking king and rook.

The Legal Trap (Legal’s Mate):

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 d6 3. Bc4 Bg4 4. Nc3 g6? 5. Nxe5!! Bxd1??
6. Bxf7+ Ke7 7. Nd5#

White sacrifices the queen for checkmate! This works because Black gets greedy.

Traps You'll Face as Black

Scholar's Mate (revisited):

1. e4 e5 2. Bc4 Nc6 3. Qh5 Nf6?? 4. Qxf7#

Prevention: After 3. Qh5, play 3... Qe7 or 3... g6 or 3... Qf6. Don't play 3... Nf6.

The Wayward Queen Attack:

1. e4 e5 2. Qh5?!

White brings the queen out on move 2. It's not *that* dangerous if you stay calm:

2... Nc6 (Develop, defend e5)
3. Bc4 g6 (Attack the queen, gain tempo)
4. Qf3 Nf6 (Develop again, attack the queen!)

White has moved the queen twice and still hasn't developed a minor piece. Black is already better.

4.6 Castling: When, Where, and Why

When to Castle

Castle early – by move 10 at the latest. Earlier is usually better (move 4-6 is ideal when possible).

Kingside (O-O) vs. Queenside (O-O-O)

Kingside (O-O)	Queenside (O-O-O)
Faster (only N+B to move)	Slower (Q-side pieces to move)
King safer (protected by 3 pawns)	King somewhat exposed (a-file)
Default choice	Aggressive, attacking choice
95% of games at this level	Use only when you understand why

Recommendation: Castle kingside in 95% of your games until ELO 1000+.

Don't Push Pawns in Front of Your King

After castling, the pawns on f2/g2/h2 (or f7/g7/h7) are your king's shield. Every pawn you push weakens this shield.

When it's OK to push: - h3/h6 (or a3/a6) to prevent a bishop pin - When your opponent has no pieces near your king - To create "luft" (air) against back-rank mate

When it's NOT OK: - Chasing a piece that will just retreat - "Because I felt like it" - When the opponent is attacking on that side

4.7 Transitioning to the Middlegame

The opening ends when: - Both players have developed most pieces - Kings are castled - Rooks are connected

Now what? The middlegame begins. At the 600-800 level, your middlegame plan:

Form a Plan (Not Just Random Moves!)

After development, ask yourself:

1. **Where are the weaknesses?** (Backward pawns, open files, weak squares)
2. **Which side of the board should I play on?** (Where you have more space/pieces)
3. **What's my worst piece?** (Improve it!)
4. **Can I create a threat?** (CCT scan!)

The Rook Question

After castling, rooks belong on **open files** (files with no pawns) or **semi-open files** (files with only enemy pawns). Don't leave rooks sitting in the corner.

If the e-file is open after pawn exchanges, put your rook on e1 (or e8). A rook on an open file controls the entire file.

4.8 Opening Repertoire Summary

White (with 1. e4)

Black's Response	Your Line
1... e5	Italian Game (3. Bc4)
1... e6 (French)	2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 (or 3. Nd2 Tarrasch)
1... c5 (Sicilian)	2. Nf3 followed by 3. d4 (Open Sicilian)
1... c6 (Caro-Kann)	2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 (Classical)
Anything else	Occupy center, develop, castle

Black

White's Move	Your Response
1. e4	1... e5 (Classical) or 1... d5 (Scandinavian)
1. d4	1... d5 (Closed Game)
1. Nf3	1... d5 (Claim center)
1. c4	1... e5 or 1... c5 (Claim center)

Chapter 4 Summary

Concept	Key Point
White opening	Italian Game (1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4)
Black opening	1... e5 (classical) or 1... d5 (Scandinavian)
Tempo	Develop with threat whenever possible
Castling	Kingside, by move 10
Traps	Know Scholar's Mate and how to defend it
Rooks	Place on open files

Checkpoint: Can you play the first 8 moves of the Italian Game from memory? Do you know how to defend against Scholar's Mate? Do you castle kingside by move 10? If yes, proceed to Chapter 5. # Chapter 5: Endgame Essentials (ELO 800 -> 1000)

"The hardest thing in chess is to win a won game." – Frank Marshall

At ELO 800-1000, many players can get a winning position but fail to convert it. They reach the endgame up a piece and still manage to draw – or worse, lose. This chapter teaches you how to win the games you're supposed to win.

5.1 The Endgame Mindset Shift

In the middlegame, you think about attacks, tactics, and piece coordination. In the endgame, the priorities change:

Middlegame Priority	Endgame Priority
Attack the king	Activate your king
Coordinate pieces	Push passed pawns
Create threats	Restrict opponent's king
Avoid trades (if attacking)	Trade down to simplification

The biggest mindset shift: In the endgame, your king transforms from a liability to an asset. Bring it to the center!

5.2 King Activity – The King Becomes a Fighter

When queens are off the board and only a few pieces remain, the king should march to the center.

The Rule of the Square

Before pushing a passed pawn, check if the enemy king can catch it.

The Square Rule: Draw an imaginary square from the pawn to the promotion square. If the enemy king is inside the square (or can step into it on its turn), the king catches the pawn. If not, the pawn promotes.

White pawn on d4, Black king on h8.

The square: d4-d8-h8-h4. The Black king is on h8 -- inside the square!

The king can catch the pawn: ... Kg7, ... Kf6, ... Ke6, ... Kd5.

If the pawn were on d5, the square would be d5-d8-g8-g5.

Black king on h8 is outside! The pawn promotes.

Opposition

When two kings face each other with one square between them, the player who **does not** have to move has the opposition. This is a powerful zugzwang weapon.

White king on e4, Black king on e6. One square between them.

If it's Black to move, White has the opposition -- Black must give way.

... Kd6 -> White Kf5 (gains ground)

... Kf6 -> White Kd5 (gains ground)

How to use opposition: 1. Use opposition to force the enemy king to give way 2. Once the enemy king yields, advance your king 3. Use your king to escort pawns to promotion

5.3 Basic Checkmates (You MUST Know These)

If you can't checkmate with these combinations, you haven't earned ELO 800.

King + Queen vs. King

The Method: 1. Use your queen to restrict the enemy king – place her a “knight's move away” from the enemy king 2. Walk your king closer 3. When the enemy king is on the edge, deliver checkmate with queen + king

Never stalemate! When the enemy king is on the edge, make sure it has a legal square. If you put your queen too close without a check, stalemate is common.

Position: WK on d6, WQ on h7, BK on e8

1. Qg7?? -- STALEMATE! Black king on e8 has no legal moves.

Correct: 1. Qe7# (protected by the king on d6)

King + Rook vs. King

Similar to K+Q vs K, but slower. The “ladder” or “box” method:

1. Use the rook to cut off the king (a rank or file)
2. Walk your king closer
3. When kings are in opposition and the enemy king is on the edge, deliver checkmate with the rook

The box shrinks with each rook move. Enemy king is pushed to the edge. Requires patience -- this can take 15+ moves. Practice it!

Key positions to memorize: - K+R vs K: King on a1/a8/h1/h8, rook delivers mate on the edge - K+Q vs K: Queen protected by king on the mating square

King + Two Bishops vs. King

Harder but important. The two bishops work together to push the king to a corner. The king must end up in a corner of the same color as one of the bishops.

Important: At ELO 800-1000, if you’re defending this, make them prove it. Many players at this level don’t know how to do it within the 50-move rule.

5.4 Passed Pawns – The Most Important Endgame Concept

A **passed pawn** is a pawn that has no enemy pawns in front of it (on its file or adjacent files) that can block or capture it.

Why Passed Pawns Win Games

A passed pawn is a constant threat to promote to a queen. Your opponent must dedicate pieces to stopping it – while you use your other pieces to attack elsewhere.

The principle of two weaknesses: Create a passed pawn on one side, force the opponent’s pieces to stop it, then attack on the other side. The opponent’s pieces can’t be in two places at once.

Creating a Passed Pawn

The Pawn Breakthrough:

White pawns on a5, b5, c5. Black pawns on a7, b7, c7.

1. b6! axb6 (or cxb6)
2. c6! bxc6
3. a6! and the a-pawn promotes.

Two pawns are sacrificed so the third can break through!

The Outside Passed Pawn

A passed pawn far from the main action is a “decisive advantage.” Your opponent’s king must go to stop it, leaving your king free to devour pawns on the other side.

Pawns on the kingside. White has a passed pawn on the a-file.

White pushes the a-pawn. Black's king must chase it.

Meanwhile, White's king walks to the kingside and captures all Black's pawns. White wins easily.

5.5 Pawn Endgames – King and Pawn(s) vs. King

King + Pawn vs. King

The most fundamental endgame. Whether it’s a win or draw depends on **key squares** and **opposition**.

Key Squares for a pawn on the 5th rank: For a White pawn on e5, the key squares are d6, e6, f6. If White’s king can occupy any of these, the pawn promotes.

Key Squares for a pawn on the 4th rank: For a White pawn on e4, the key squares are d5, e5, f5 (one rank closer to home).

The Rule: If the attacking king can reach a key square, the pawn promotes and wins. If the defending king prevents this, it’s a draw.

The Trebuchet (Mutual Zugzwang)

White king on e5, White pawn on d5. Black king on d7.

White to move: 1. Kd4 Kd6 2. Ke4 Ke6 -- DRAW (defender holds opposition)

Black to move: 1... Ke7 2. Ke6! (reaches key square) Kd8 3. d6 Kc8 4. Ke7 -- WIN

Whoever moves LOSES. This is a trebuchet position.

King + Two Pawns vs. King

Usually an easy win. But beware: if one pawn is a rook pawn (a-file or h-file) and the defending king can get in front of both, it can be drawn!

5.6 Rook Endgames – The Most Common Endgame

Most games that reach the endgame will have rooks on the board. Rook endgames are the most common and most difficult endgames in chess.

The Lucena Position (Rook + Pawn vs. Rook – Winning)

When your king is on the promotion square and your pawn is on the 7th rank, use the “building a bridge” method:

White: Kd8, Re4, pawn e7. Black: Kf7, Ra2.

White wins by "building a bridge":

1. Re1 (or Re2, Re3) -- the rook prepares to shield the king
 2. ... Ra8+ 3. Kd7 Ra7+ 4. Kd6 Ra6+ 5. Re6! -- the bridge is built
- The king escapes checks along the e-file, and the pawn promotes.

The Philidor Position (Rook + Pawn vs. Rook – Defending)

The defender’s rook stays on the 3rd rank, preventing the enemy king from advancing:

Black rook on e6 (3rd rank), Black king on e7. White pawn on e5, king on e4. Black holds the draw by keeping the rook on the 3rd rank until the pawn advances to e6, then the rook drops back to the 1st rank for endless checks.

If Black leaves the 3rd rank, White's king advances and wins.

Key Rule: In rook endgames, the rook belongs BEHIND the passed pawn – yours or your opponent’s.

5.7 The Principle of Two Weaknesses

One threat is defensible. Two simultaneous threats are not.

How to Win a “Won” Endgame

1. **Create a passed pawn** (first weakness)
2. **Force the opponent’s king/rook to stop it**
3. **While they’re occupied, attack elsewhere** (second weakness)
4. **The opponent can’t defend both – something falls**

This is how masters win endgames. At ELO 800-1000, if you apply this principle, you'll convert positions your opponents would draw.

5.8 Practical Endgame Advice

When You're Winning

1. **Trade pieces, not pawns.** Fewer pieces = simpler position = less chance to blunder.
2. **Don't rush.** In the endgame, time is on your side if you're winning. Make sure you don't blunder.
3. **Beware of stalemate.** When your opponent has only a king, every move must give them a legal move (unless it's checkmate).
4. **Centralize your king.** In the endgame, a centralized king is worth more than a rook.

When You're Losing

1. **Don't trade pawns.** Fewer pawns = fewer chances for counterplay.
2. **Keep pieces on.** More pieces = more complexity = more chances for opponent to blunder.
3. **Look for stalemate tricks.** A lone king can still draw if you set up a stalemate trap.
4. **Create a passed pawn.** Your only chance is to create counterplay.

The 50-Move Rule

If 50 moves pass without a pawn move or capture, either player can claim a draw. This matters in K+Q vs K and K+R vs K – if you take 50+ moves, your opponent can claim a draw!

5.9 Endgame Study Plan

Week 1: Practice K+Q vs K until you can do it in under 20 seconds (any position). **Week 2:** Practice K+R vs K until you can do it in under 30 seconds. **Week 3:** Study king + pawn vs. king – key squares, opposition, the square rule. **Week 4:** Basic rook + pawn vs. rook – Philidor and Lucena positions. **Week 5+:** Solve 10 endgame puzzles per day. Use the Chess99 Tactical Trainer or Lichess.

Chapter 5 Summary

Endgame Skill	Benchmark
K+Q vs K	Win in under 20 seconds from any position
K+R vs K	Win in under 30 seconds from any position
Opposition	Know how to use it to escort a pawn
Square Rule	Know instantly if king can catch a passed pawn
Passed Pawns	Create them, push them, win with them
Simplify to win	Trade pieces (not pawns) when ahead

Checkpoint: Can you checkmate with K+Q vs K and K+R vs K without thinking? Do you understand opposition and the square rule? Can you win a won endgame instead of drawing it? If yes, proceed to Chapter 6. # Chapter 6: Practical Play & Avoiding Blunders (All Levels)

“The blunders are all there on the board, waiting to be made.” – Savielly Tartakower

This chapter applies to every ELO level. The difference between an 800-rated player and a 1000-rated player is often not more knowledge – it’s fewer blunders.

6.1 The Blunder Hierarchy

Not all mistakes are equal. Understanding the types helps you prioritize what to fix:

Type	Example	ELO Cost	How to Fix
Hanging a piece	Moving a queen to an attacked square	-200	CCT scan
Missing a tactic	Not seeing a fork on your queen	-150	CCT scan
One-move blunder	Moving a defended piece to an undefended square next to attacker	-100	Blunder check
Positional mistake	Trading bishop for knight in closed position	-30	Study, experience
Opening inaccuracy	Playing Na3 on move 1	-20	Opening knowledge

Fix the top three first. At the 0-1000 level, 90% of losses come from the top three. The CCT scan (Chapter 3) addresses all of them.

6.2 The Blunder Prevention Protocol

This is your practical system for avoiding blunders in real games. Use it on every move.

Step 1: Opponent's Last Move – What Changed?

The moment your opponent moves, ask: “What does that move do?”

- What squares does that piece now attack?
- What was that piece defending that it no longer defends?
- Was there a discovered attack?
- Did they just hang a piece?

This takes 3 seconds. If you do nothing else, do this.

Step 2: CCT Scan (Your Turn)

Checks: "Do I have any checks?"

Captures: "What can I capture? In what order?"

Threats: "What threats can I create?"

Step 3: Choose Your Move

Select your candidate move. Now STOP. Don't play it yet.

Step 4: Blunder Check

Before touching the piece, verify:

1. **Is the destination square safe?** – Is it attacked by any enemy piece?
By how many?
2. **What am I leaving undefended?** – The square I'm leaving – was my piece defending something important?
3. **What's their best reply?** – After my move, what check/capture/threat do they have?
4. **Am I walking into a discovered attack?** – Moving this piece – does it uncover an attack from me? From them?

This takes 5 seconds. It will save you more games than any other single habit.

Step 5: Play the Move

Only now, after the full protocol, make your move.

6.3 Common Blunder Patterns and Their Fixes

Pattern 1: “I didn’t see the bishop”

The long-range bishop or queen on the other side of the board captures your piece.

Fix: Before moving, trace the diagonals from every enemy bishop and queen. Are any of your pieces on those diagonals? Are you moving a piece *onto* one of those diagonals?

Visual habit: When you’re about to move, run your eyes along the diagonals from the enemy queen and bishops. Every move.

Pattern 2: “Knight forks everywhere”

You move your king and queen to squares a knight’s fork away from each other.

Fix: Check if any enemy knight can reach a square that forks two of your valuable pieces (especially king + queen, queen + rook).

The test: “If the enemy had a knight on [every square a knight can reach], would any of those fork my pieces?” Especially squares that attack both the king and queen.

Pattern 3: “I captured the wrong thing”

You saw a capture, played it instantly, and realized too late it was a trap.

Fix: When you see a free piece, ask: “Why is it free? Is this a trap?” If a piece looks undefended but your opponent just moved something else, they might be baiting you.

The “too good to be true” rule: If a capture looks too easy, take 10 extra seconds. There’s probably a reason.

Pattern 4: “I forgot about pins”

You moved a pinned piece, exposing your king or queen to immediate capture.

Fix: When your opponent has a bishop, rook, or queen aligned with your king or queen, check if any of your pieces are between them. Those pieces are pinned – they can’t move (or shouldn’t).

Pattern 5: “Back rank checkmate”

Your king is on g1/g8, pawns on f2/g2/h2 (or f7/g7/h7), and you don’t notice the enemy rook/queen is about to deliver back rank mate.

Fix: If your castling pawns haven’t moved (no “luft”), be paranoid about back rank threats. Play h3/h6 or g3/g6 early enough to give your king an escape square.

6.4 Time Management

The Time Problem at This Level

Two types of players at ELO 0-1000:

1. **The Speed Demon:** Plays every move in 2 seconds. Blunders by move 15.
2. **The Overthinker:** Spends 3 minutes on move 4. Gets into time trouble by move 25.

The Solution: Time Budgeting

For a 10-minute game (10|0):

Phase	Moves	Time Budget
Opening	1-8	1 minute total
Early middlegame	9-20	3 minutes
Late middlegame	21-35	3 minutes
Endgame	36+	3 minutes

Critical moves deserve more time: - When there’s a possible capture sequence (spend 20-30 seconds) - When you’re about to win or lose material (spend 30-60 seconds) - When your king is in danger (spend as long as needed)

Non-critical moves deserve less time: - Forced recaptures (play quickly) - Obvious developing moves in the opening (play quickly) - When there’s only one legal move (play instantly)

The Time Check Habit

Every 5 moves, glance at the clock. Ask: “Am I too fast? Too slow? Do I need to speed up or slow down?”

6.5 The Psychology of Not Blundering

Tilt Management

You just blundered your queen. What now?

The wrong response: “I’m an idiot.” *Makes 5 more bad moves and loses immediately.*

The right response: Take a deep breath. Stand up if you’re at a physical board. Close your eyes for 10 seconds. The game isn’t over – your opponent still has to prove they can win. Many players get overconfident after winning material and blunder back.

The comeback mindset: “I’m down material, but there are still pieces on the board. I need to create complications and look for tactics. If I trade off everything and simplify, I definitely lose. I need chaos.”

Don’t Resign

At ELO 0-1000: - Opponents stalemate you when up 15 points of material - Opponents flag (run out of time) in winning positions - Opponents hang their queen back to “balance things out”

Unless you’re facing checkmate in 1 move and there’s no escape, don’t resign.

The “One Good Move” Mindset

You don’t need to play 40 perfect moves. You need to play fewer bad moves than your opponent. Focus on not blundering, and their blunders will come.

6.6 Game Review – The Fastest Path to Improvement

Playing 100 games without reviewing them is nearly useless. Playing 10 games and deeply reviewing each one is how you improve.

The 5-Minute Review Protocol

After each game:

1. **Find the decisive mistake.** At what point did the evaluation swing from equal to +3 (or -3)? What was that move? Why did you play it?
2. **Replay from that position.** If you hadn’t made that mistake, what would you have played? What was the correct plan?
3. **Identify the pattern.** Was this a hanging piece? A missed tactic? A positional misunderstanding? Write it down.

4. **Set a goal for next game.** Based on your mistake, pick ONE thing to focus on. “Next game, I will scan for enemy bishop diagonals on every move.”

Using the Chess99 Game Review

The Chess99 platform provides a game review with move-by-move navigation. Use it to: - Step through your game after it ends - Identify exactly where the game was won or lost - Look at critical positions and ask: “What was I thinking here?”

6.7 Study Plan: From 0 to 1000 ELO

Daily Routine (30-45 minutes per day)

Activity	Time	Purpose
Tactics puzzles	15 minutes	Pattern recognition, CCT practice
Play one serious game	10-15 minutes	Application of principles
Review your game	5-10 minutes	Learn from mistakes
Study one concept	5-10 minutes	New knowledge (rotating topics)

Weekly Focus

Week	Focus	Resource
1	Board setup, piece movement, ladder mate	Chapter 1
2	Opening principles, forks/pins/skewers	Chapter 2
3	CCT scan habit, blunder check protocol	Chapter 3
4	Italian Game (White), 1...e5 or Scandinavian (Black)	Chapter 4
5	K+Q vs K, K+R vs K, opposition, passed pawns	Chapter 5

Week	Focus	Resource
6	Practical play, time management, game review	Chapter 6
7+	Rotate through all chapters, focusing on weaknesses	All chapters

Milestones

ELO	What You Should Be Able to Do
200	Set up board correctly, move all pieces, know values
400	Control center, develop, castle, spot forks
600	Run CCT scan automatically, avoid blunders
800	Play a sound opening, win basic endgames
1000	Convert winning positions, manage time, review games

6.8 Using the Chess99 Tactical Trainer for Improvement

The Chess99 Tactical Progression Trainer is built on the CCT framework. Use it to practice exactly what this book teaches:

Stage 0: Beginner Tactics (ELO 800-1400 puzzles)

Focus on basic tactical patterns: forks, pins, skewers. Run the CCT scan on every puzzle. Don't skip the CCT phases – they're the most important part.

Goal: Solve 15 puzzles correctly in Stage 0 to unlock Stage 1.

Stage 1: Tactical Sharpness (ELO 1400-1650 puzzles)

Longer sequences, more complex patterns. Practice calculating 2-3 moves ahead. Continue running the CCT scan.

Goal: Solve 20 puzzles in Stage 1 to unlock Stage 2.

Training Tips

- **Accuracy over speed:** It's better to solve 5 puzzles with 100% accuracy than 20 puzzles with 25%.
- **Use slow mode first:** Complete the full CCT analysis for each puzzle. Only switch to fast mode when the CCT scan has become automatic.
- **Review your wrong attempts:** The trainer shows you the solution. Understand WHY the solution works and WHY your move didn't.

Chapter 6 Summary

Skill	Action
Blunder check	5-step protocol on every move
Common patterns	Bishop diagonals, knight forks, pins, back rank, traps
Time management	Budget your time; spend it on critical moves
Psychology	Don't resign, manage tilt, focus on one move at a time
Game review	5-minute protocol after every game
CCT practice	Tactical trainer, 15 mins/day, use CCT phases

Final Words

Chess is a journey, not a destination. ELO 1000 is not the end – it's the beginning of real chess understanding. The principles in this book will serve you well beyond 1000 ELO.

Three things to remember:

1. **CCT on every move.** Checks, Captures, Threats. Make it automatic.
2. **Blunder check before you move.** 5 seconds. It's your insurance policy.
3. **Review your games.** Each game has one lesson. Find it.

The player who makes the fewest mistakes wins. Be that player.

Good luck. See you at 1000.

This e-book was created with the pedagogical framework from the Chess99 Tactical Progression Trainer (chess99.com). The CCT (Checks, Captures, Threats) system is the core teaching method used across all Chess99 learning tools.